INFANTRY UNIFORM

The British infantryman's uniform in World War I owed its khaki colour to the experience of troops in India in the 19th century and in the Boer War of 1899–1902. Effective as camouflage in the hot, dry plains of southern Africa, it was retained in the muddy trenches of Flanders. Its colour was not as important to a soldier's safety as not showing his silhouette above ground. The one important change in the uniform in the course of the war was the introduction of the steel helmet in 1916.

Hats, caps, and helmets
The men who went to war in August 1914 wore a variety of headgear according to their regiment. Most common was the standard service cap *(below)*. As casualties mounted, all the combatants realized the need for steel helmets. The Brodie helmet (or "tin hat") became standard issue in 1916.



BRODIE HELMET



Canvas camouflage cover for steel helmet



Backpack and helmet
The pack, in which a soldier kept his greatcoat, other spare clothes, and personal effects was part of the standard 1908 pattern webbing. He would often have left it behind the lines when serving a stint in the front line trench. He could never be without his steel helmet when within range of enemy artillery.

Uniform and webbing
The tunic, trousers, and webbing shown here are those of a regular army infantryman of 1914. He would also have had a heavy greatcoat and a sleeveless sheepskin jacket for winter wear.

Canvas belt and cartridge pouches

Regimental badge on shoulder



Clips stored in ammunition pouch

